

After the Story: Somebody Else First

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A companion study to *The 3:10 Shift*

Back to the Lot

Pull your chair in, and let's go back to the spring of 2020 for a while.

You remember the hospital lot on Cedar Crest. Cars sat with the engines off, and the people inside them waited on phone calls. A woman had a rosary hanging from her mirror, and a man in a pickup rested his forehead on the steering wheel. Upstairs, nobody's family was allowed past the doors. Down the road, Walt Kostelnik's daughter talked to him through a storm door with a mask on, because she would not carry the ward into his kitchen. The churches had gone to parking lots and then to screens. A lot of people prayed alone that spring, if they prayed at all.

Walt hadn't prayed. June was the believer. He drove her to church and sat in the truck with the radio low. Then she died behind a visitor ban, and the answering machine on the hall table started playing her old tapes back to him. At the end of the story it played a tape he had never heard, with June's voice saying, "let him pray for somebody else first," and the machine read off a time stamp of 3:10 in the morning. Theresa was in that room the night her mother died. All she heard was the ventilator.

Deshawn tells us straight out that he won't put a bridge between those two facts. Tonight we won't either. We're going to ask a different question. What do you do with a voice like that, and what did Walt do with it?

Questions to Sit With

1. Read 1 John 4:1. If a voice like June's came out of a machine on your hall table, what would you do first? Why does John tell us to test spirits instead of trusting every voice that sounds like home?
2. Read Luke 22:31-32, the verse June marked "3:10, for Walt." Who prayed for whom, and when? What was Peter supposed to do once he came back?

3. Read 1 John 4:20-21. Walt prayed his first prayer out loud for a man he had never met, whose boy was sitting in a gray Honda two rows over. Why does John tie loving God so tightly to loving the people we can see?

The Teaching: Test It Against What God Already Said

Start with the test, because the story puts it right in Walt's hands. John wrote to churches full of new voices, and he told them plainly not to believe every spirit, but to test the spirits to see whether they come from God (1 John 4:1). The first test he gives is a confession. A spirit from God confesses that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh (1 John 4:2-3). That's the line that held on South Mountain in our last story, and it still holds. Notice that June's tape never makes a claim like that, one way or the other. It never says who sent it. It brings no new teaching about God. It doesn't ask Walt to worship anybody or follow anybody. So we don't build a doctrine on it, and we don't hang our faith on it. Walt didn't either. He wrote JUNE FINAL on the label and set it back in the shoe box.

There's a second way to test it, and that's to lay the message beside what God has already said. Norman Geisler and Frank Turek explain that when God does a true miracle, He does it to back up His word, the way a king put his seal on a letter so people would know it came from him. In their words, "a miracle is an act of God to confirm the word of God through a messenger of God" (Geisler and Turek, ch. 8, pp. 201-2). The word comes first. So weigh the words on that tape. Pray for somebody else first. You don't need a cassette to hear that. Jesus taught His friends to pray for the people who mistreated them (Matthew 5:44). Paul told the Philippians to look out for the interests of others and not only their own (Philippians 2:4). James says to pray for one another (James 5:16). Whatever was on that tape, the instruction on it was already sitting in June's Bible on the nightstand.

Look at the page June marked. In Luke 22, on the night before the cross, Jesus told Peter that Satan wanted to sift him like wheat. Then He said, I have prayed for you, that your faith won't fail, and when you have turned back, strengthen your brothers (Luke 22:31-32). Jesus prayed for Peter before Peter ever fell. Peter fell anyway, three times before the rooster crowed. Then he came back, and he spent the rest of his life strengthening other people. June wrote "3:10, for Walt" beside that verse. For years she went into the back bedroom around that hour with the door

half shut, and Walt figured she was reading and never asked. The note in her margin tells us who that half hour was for. She was praying for him before he knew how to pray. And when he finally turned, the first thing he did was strengthen somebody else.

Now the lockdown. John Lennox wrote *Where is God in a Coronavirus World?* in the first weeks of that spring, sitting at home in his mid-seventies with his wife, close to Walt's age, watching a health minister on television tell them they might be shut in for months. He doesn't pretend to have every answer. In his postscript he admits he's left with "many ragged edges" (Lennox, Postscript). The church has always lived with those, and Deshawn's two facts are ragged edges too. What Lennox does give is a way to stand on that ground. He says keeping our distance in a plague can be love: "social distancing is not an expression of selfishness but of loving one's neighbours enough to protect them" (Lennox, ch. 6). That's Theresa at the storm door. Staying on the porch was the way she loved her father.

Lennox also goes back through the old plagues and shows how Christians in the Roman Empire stayed and nursed the sick when other people ran, and how Martin Luther refused to leave plague-struck Wittenberg in 1527 and stayed with the sick, at a cost to his own family (Lennox, ch. 6). Theresa was standing that same post on the third floor at Cedar Crest. She had thirty seconds between tasks and a gloved hand on the rail, and she spent them praying for Marcus, for Deshawn, and for her dad sitting in that house.

Then there's the hardest question in the story, the one nobody says out loud. June prayed for years and died anyway, with only her daughter there, holding her hand through a glove. Marcus lived. Where was God in that? Geisler and Turek take that question head on. They answer that God "may have permitted evil in order to defeat it," and they point to Job, who comes out of his trouble a deeper man than he went in (Geisler and Turek, appendix 1, p. 400). Lennox points to a different crown than the one in the news that spring: "hope is found in another corona: the crown of thorns that was forced on Jesus' head at his trial before his execution" (Lennox, ch. 5). God didn't watch that spring from a safe distance. He came down into His own world and died on a cross, and He walked out of the tomb on the third day. He knows what a sealed door is. And for the days we can't see what He's doing, Lennox leans on the old preacher Charles Spurgeon: "when we cannot trace His hand, we must trust His heart" (Spurgeon, quoted in Lennox, Postscript).

Last, look at what the fear did. June's tape ends, "I'm not afraid." John wrote that there is no fear in love, and that perfect love drives fear out (1 John 4:18). A few verses earlier he wrote that nobody has ever seen God, but if we love one another, God lives in us and His love is made complete in us (1 John 4:12). What people in that story got to see was an old man in a parking lot with his cap in both hands, and a nurse with thirty seconds to spare.

Around the Fire: Talk It Over and Take It Home

Talk about where faith started for Walt. It didn't start with the tape. Look at what he did on Saturday before the last tape ever played. He drove to the lot, set two paper cups on Theresa's car, and took his cap off at ten after three for a man named Marcus. He told God he didn't know how this worked, and then he asked anyway. Is there anybody you've been waiting to pray for until you get your questions sorted out? Walt didn't wait.

Talk about the empty rooms of 2020. Some of you lost people that year and couldn't be in the room. Some of you watched church on a laptop at the kitchen table, like Deshawn did with school. Say out loud what that spring was like for your family. Then ask what you carried out of it. Walt carried a shift, and Theresa carried her post at the bedside. What did you carry?

Then talk about now. The bans are long over. The lot on Cedar Crest has visitors again. The danger now is forgetting what we learned with the doors shut, that prayer can cross a locked hallway when our feet can't. Walt kept the shift for years after Marcus came home, because, as he told Deshawn, "Somebody is always on a hard clock somewhere." Somebody you know is on one tonight.

Try this, this week. Pick a time, any time, and set an alarm for it. When it goes off, pray for one person before you pray for yourself. Write their name on a calendar if that helps, the way Walt penciled 3:10 into every square for the rest of that April and hung it back crooked. Learn 1 John 4:12 by heart. And if a voice ever comes to you from a strange place, sounding like someone you love, don't chase it. Test it against what God has already said, then go do what He already told you. Take the shift.

Works Cited

Geisler, Norman L., and Frank Turek. *I Don't Have Enough Faith to Be an Atheist*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway Books, 2004.

Lennox, John C. *Where is God in a Coronavirus World?* N.p.: The Good Book Company, 2020.